

1974

A model wearing a 'mini-saree' by Mohanjeet. This was an iconic creation of the designer



1996

Hollywood actress Cameron Diaz wearing a kimono made from a red and gold Banarasi saree designed by Mohanjeet

2021

The Indian Embassy in Paris felicitates Mohanjeet Grewal for her achievements in the field of fashion and her store completing 50 years



2022

A model at a street fashion show by Mohanjeet, celebrating beauty everywhere, with models from any age, size or colour, under Parisian Platanes trees at the famous Boulevard de Port-Royal, Paris

spotted on global runways. But what is not widely known is that Grewal—or Mohanjeet as she is known in fashion circles—has had a big part to play in introducing the grandeur of Indian fashion and fabrics to the world.

“Mohanjeet has been critical in letting the world know about Indian craftsmanship and creativity. Her work and personality are building stones for India’s textile power and crafts at large,” says Vaishali Shadangule, who owns a Mumbai-based eponymous couture brand and has also showcased Indian weaves at the Paris Haute Couture Week.

It was in April of 1964 that Grewal became the first Indian designer to set up a store on Rue de Bac, a fabled street on the left bank of Paris. Called “La Malle de l’Inde”, or The Indian Trunk, she literally brought in trunk-loads of Indian textiles into France with 3,000 francs loaned by a friend; she borrowed another 7,000 francs from another friend to set up the shop. This store took the world’s fashion capital by storm “at once” says Grewal, who can well be called the *grande dame* of Indian high fashion.

We are meeting at her tastefully done-up home at Nizamuddin in Delhi, and her living room seems to reflect her personality. There are books, magazines, art, and huge posters of Andy Warhol and Raphael. On the walls are Grewal’s photographs from her younger days as also photos she has clicked, including those of Indira Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, who she interviewed many times while working as a scribe. She clearly has a thing for Buddha statues, as 37 of them in varied sizes adorn her living room, along with other bric-a-brac.

What is absent is a television set. Ask her about it and she says: “I